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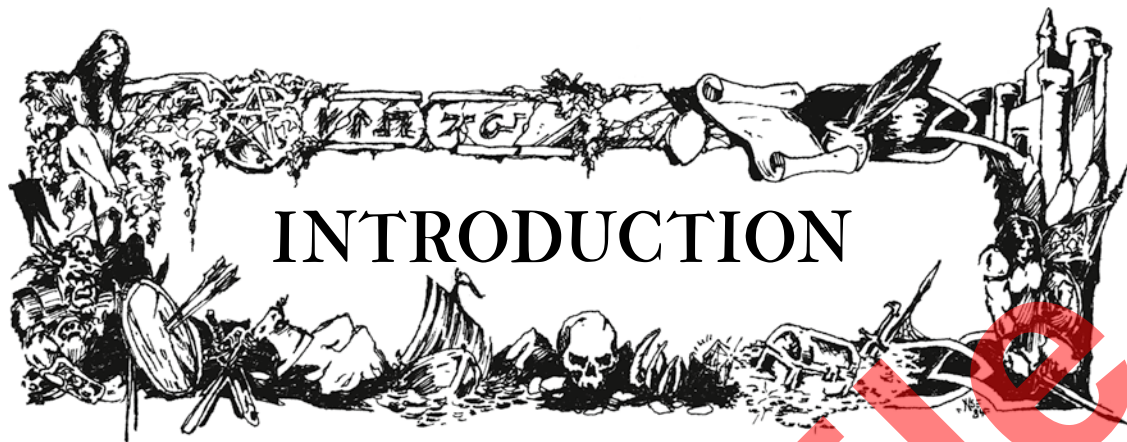
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INTRODUCTION

Did you hear the story of the Forbidden Lands? Beyond the mountains, beyond the mists of the north? Once, it was called the Ravenland, our promised land. These days, strange creatures haunt those valleys, beasts that should not be, for the land is cursed.



Once, Zygofer the Spellbinder was one of us, leading the passage through the mountains into the new land. But when faced by the savage orcs, he opened dark gates to seek the help of demons. That was his undoing. Zygofer turned on us and placed himself on the throne of the Ravenland, his daughter Therania by his side.

To keep their vile corruption from spreading, our wise king built a great wall across the mountain pass and forbade all to ever speak of what had happened. Since then, the Spellbinder's domain is known as the Forbidden Lands.

To this day, the demon-king and his daughter still rule there. Using the feared Rust Brothers, and the demonic Blood Mist sucking the life out of anyone who dared stray too far from their hearth, Zygofer and Therania have kept the human folks who still live north of the wall under their beel.

Yet, not all is lost. For now, the Blood Mist has lifted and there are those who dare defy the de-

mon-king and his daughter. Adventurers. Treasure hunters. Scoundrels. Not heroes, far from it, but men and women who dare travel the land as they choose and make their own mark on it, unbound by any fate or story set for them. They hunt for ancient treasures, they fight whomsoever gets in their way, they build a new world for themselves on the ruins of the old.

They are the raiders of the Forbidden Lands.

FORBIDDEN LANDS

Welcome to the free quickstart for *Forbidden Lands*. In this tabletop roleplaying game, you are not heroes sent on missions dictated by others – instead, you are raiders and rogues bent on making your own mark on a cursed world. You will wander the wild lands, discover lost



tombs, fight monsters, and, if you live long enough, build your own stronghold to defend. During your adventures, you will uncover the secrets of dark powers lurking in the shadows and, in the end, you can be the ones to decide the fate of the *Forbidden Lands*.

THE PLAYERS

Each player except one portrays an adventurer, a player character (PC). You decide what your PC thinks and feels, what she says and does – but not what happens to her. It is your job as a player to immerse yourself in your PC. She may be an adventurer from a faraway fantasy world – but she is still, at heart, a person with feelings and dreams, just like you. Try to imagine – how would you react if you were in her shoes? What would you do? The player characters are always the protagonists of the story. The game is about you. Your decisions, your adventures.

THE GAMEMASTER

The final player is the Gamemaster, the GM. She describes the *Forbidden Lands* to you, she plays the people you meet during your journeys, she controls the monsters roaming the forests, she decides where the treasure is buried. The game is a conversation between the players and the GM, back and forth, until a critical situation arises where the outcome is uncertain. Then it's time to break out the dice – read more about this in Chapter 3.

It is the GM's job to put obstacles in your path and challenge your PCs, forcing them to show what they're really made of. But it is not up to the GM to decide everything that hap-

pens in the game – and above all, not how your story is supposed to end. That is decided in the game. That is why you are playing the game, to find out how your story ends.

Being the GM can be overwhelming and fraught with responsibility, as if the whole game rests on your shoulders. Don't fear! This quickstart contains useful random encounters as we all as a complete adventure site, called Weatherstone (see page 113), and the full *Forbidden Lands* game contains a host of useful tools for the GM.



WHAT DO YOU DO?

There is no one to hold your hand and show you where to go in the *Forbidden Lands*. It is up to you and the other players to decide where you are going, together. The GM will let you make fantastic discoveries and face tough challenges, but in the end the stories of the game are created by you, they are not written down beforehand. You have control over your adventurers' lives and, one day, the fate of all of the *Forbidden Lands*. And there is plenty to do:

EXPLORE THE WORLD

The demonic Blood Mist that covered the lands for three centuries, draining the life out of anyone who dared to wander too far from their village, has suddenly and inexplicably lifted. You, and other restless souls like you, are finally free to leave your homes and travel far and wide in the *Forbidden Lands*, looking for treasures and adventures.



This quickstart contains a section of the large map of the Forbidden Lands found in the full game. The map is divided into ten different types of terrain and has a hexagonal grid that will help you navigate through the wilderness. How all this works is described in Chapter 5 of this quickstart.

DISCOVER ADVENTURE SITES

If you look closer at the map, you will find small symbols in many of the hexes. They denote three kinds of adventure sites – villages, castles, and dungeons. An adventure site is an exciting location your adventurer can visit, filled with intrigue, horror, and treasure. Exactly which adventure site goes with every specific symbol on the map is up to the GM to decide.

There is one complete adventure site in this quickstart – the castle Weatherstone. In the full Forbidden Lands game you'll find more adventure sites, and many more are available in modules like *Raven's Purge* and *The Spire of Quetzal*.

UNCOVER THE SECRETS OF THE LAND

When the game begins, your adventurers don't know much more than you do as players. The Blood Mist covered the land for centuries and contact between the different regions of the Forbidden Lands has been sporadic. The history of the land has been forgotten or become myth.

During the course of the game, you will discover the history and secrets of the *Forbidden Lands* piece by piece. This happens through so-called *legends*, short stories about a place, a

person, or an artifact. The GM will give you these legends in the form of handouts. Some such handouts are collected at the back of this quickstart, and many more are available as for download from the Free League website. By collecting the legends you will be able to piece together the history of the Forbidden Lands.

SEARCH FOR THE FOUR ELVEN GEMSTONES

Dark powers are stirring in the Forbidden Lands. Zygofer's henchmen, the feared Rust Brothers, still haunt the land, but the spell-binder himself has not been seen for centuries. His enemies and his allies are setting plans in motion. The Blood Mist covering the land has lifted and the deathly calm that has reigned for so long is about to shatter.

While your adventurers are free to roam the land as you see fit, there is a larger scheme behind the scenes that you can get involved in. In the epic *Raven's Purge* campaign module, your adventurers hunt for four powerful artifacts, adorned with Elven gemstones that together have the potential to decide the future of the Forbidden Lands.

Raven's Purge is not a linear story and it has no set goal that your adventurers are expected to follow. Instead, it is a rich tapestry of legends, locations, characters, and events that the you can interact with in a multitude of ways.

BUILD YOUR STRONGHOLD

If your characters make it back from the ancient ruins alive, they will hopefully bring gold and other treasures with them. Eventu-



ally, you might feel the need to spend that treasure on something lasting – a *stronghold* of your own.

Having conquered an old castle or dungeon, your characters can turn it into a stronghold. Using fast and effective rules found in the full *Forbidden Lands* game, you can develop your stronghold, adding functions such as a forge, mill, or ramparts. You can also hire

NPCs to staff the stronghold when you are out on another adventure. The stronghold is a place to rest between adventures and a safe haven against the beasts that ravage the land. However, the stronghold needs upkeep and it might also invite the attention of others, looking to steal your riches.





RAVENLAND – THE FORBIDDEN LAND

Ravenland is a ravaged and fragmented kingdom. The area where you grew up is familiar to you, but the rest of the land you know only through stories and tales. During ten human generations, travelers were devoured by the Blood Mist, a red and ravenous haze that rose from the ground at night. Very few dared venture outside after nightfall and fewer still know for certain what lies beyond the horizon.

Recently, the Blood Mist disappeared without explanation, and everywhere people look over their shoulder anxiously. The bravest sharpen their blades and prepare to leave. They can't bear the oppressive weight of their homes and hearths any longer. Perhaps they hope to find that which was lost and take back what was theirs. Perhaps they are simply driven by an insatiable lust to see what lies beyond the horizon, to discover if the myths are true, to conquer that which remains or has been stolen, and to carve out their own place as lords of some abandoned castle ruin.

Humans have inhabited the villages of Ravenland for generations, and still they are considered intruders by elves and dwarves, who have yet to forget the ancient and bloody wars between humans and the elder kin. The elves sent their servants the orcs to war, but left them on their own when the battles became too savage, a betrayal that lives on in the songs of the orcs.

The Blood Mist may be gone, but the land may have become even more dangerous because of it. In the last stages of the Alder Wars, when the king of Alderland beyond the wall

sent armies to subdue his former governor, the spellbinder Zygofer, it is said that the wizard desperately opened gateways to demon worlds from which hordes of indescribable horrors poured out into the land. Many claim that the Blood Mist followed the invasion. What is certain is that one can run into horrifying beasts in the forests and among the ruins: completely alien or twisted combinations of various creatures that never should have existed.

It is said Zygofer is still alive, transformed into a demon and worshipped as a god by the priesthood of the Rust Brothers close to Alderstone in the west. There are whispers about half-demons and undead created to finally conquer Ravenland. At the same time, the elves are standing fast in the woods and the dwarves in their mountains, while orcs no longer serve or spare anyone. On the plains by the ocean in the east, forces are gathering to crush Zygofer once and for all, in the name of the old gods. Others simply want to live in peace – these may be the remnants of human settlements now living in hidden villages, half-elf druids, the wolfkin of the woods, or halflings in their burrows.

Ravenland is holding its breath for tomorrow.



PLAY IN OTHER WORLDS

The lore and setting of *Forbidden Lands* is rich and detailed, a new take on classic fantasy that we really hope you will enjoy. However, we also realize that many players already have their fa-